

Models and Frameworks of Professional Ethics and Behaviors

Unit 1 listed a code of conduct as one of the four marks of a profession. This unit opens that mark up. It asks what professional ethics actually are, who a teacher owes them to, and what you do on the morning when two things you owe pull in opposite directions.

That last question is the real work. Most ethical difficulty in a classroom is not a choice between doing right and doing wrong, which is usually obvious. It is a choice between two things that are both right, where honouring one costs you the other. This unit gives you two models for working through exactly that.

Unit learning outcomes

By the end of this unit you should be able to:

- Define **professional ethics** and distinguish them from personal morality and from the law, and explain why the teacher-pupil relationship needs a shared ethic of its own.
- Describe what a **code of ethical conduct** requires of a teacher toward students, toward their own practice and performance, toward parents and the community, and toward colleagues, and say what a written code can and cannot settle.
- Explain **Rest's four-component model** of moral behaviour and name where a well-meaning teacher most often fails in it.

- Apply the four-step **Empathy, Context, Reflect, Action** framework to a classroom ethical dilemma and justify the course of action you reach.
- Analyse a dilemma involving grading, confidentiality, social media or equity in which two duties genuinely conflict, and defend a decision rather than merely describe the difficulty.

Prerequisite knowledge

Unit 1, in particular the code-of-conduct dimension of professionalism and the accountability, autonomy and collegiality triad. This unit assumes you have met those ideas and opens up the first of them; it does not re-teach Unit 1.

No prior study of philosophy or ethics is assumed. Where a technical term is needed it is defined where it first appears.

In this unit

1. **Topic 2.1 - What professional ethics are, and why teaching needs them** - what the phrase means, how it differs from personal morality and from law, and why the imbalance of power between a teacher and a pupil is what makes a shared ethic necessary.
2. **Topic 2.2 - Codes of conduct, and the four people a teacher owes them to** - what is owed to students, to your own practice, to parents and community, and to colleagues, and how the local and international codes fit together.
3. **Topic 2.3 - Models for deciding: Rest, and the four-step framework** - two models of how an ethical decision is actually made, and the four distinct ways it can fail.
4. **Topic 2.4 - Dilemmas in your own classroom** - grading fairness, confidentiality, social media and equity, worked through with the models from Topic 2.3.

How to use this unit

Each topic is a complete learning cycle and takes roughly one sitting. Work through them in order, because Topic 2.4 applies the models built in Topic 2.3,

which in turn assume the codes described in Topic 2.2.

Do the activity in each topic with at least one other person if you can. Ethical reasoning improves by being challenged, and a dilemma you have only thought about privately tends to feel more obvious than it is.

The question bank at the end of the unit covers all four topics together. Its answers and mark schemes are in a clearly marked section at the foot of that page; try each item before you read them.

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